‘Never,’ I said. ‘I never said so. In fact, they beat me up for not saying that I knew Raman Srivastava.’

At this juncture, P M Nair and Ashok Kumar showed some files to Sharma to correct him that it was not Nambi Narayanan, but Sasikumaran who had given a statement that he knew Raman Srivastava.

A while later Sasi was brought in. Sharma repeated the same question to him. Sasi said he could not identify the man.

‘Then why did you tell the IB that you know him?’ Sharma said.

‘I did not initially,’ said Sasi, ‘but when I was tortured and threatened there was no option but to give a statement the way they wanted.’

Then came Mariam Rasheeda, and the same question was repeated to her. I was surprised when Mariam named him as Raman Srivastava.

‘How do you know him?’ Sharma asked.

‘Inspector Vijayan had shown me this sir’s photographs.’

‘One look at those photographs and you remembered Raman Srivastava?’

‘I was given training by inspector Vijayan,’ Mariyam was stuttering with fear. ‘He showed me several photographs and told me to memorise his face and name. I have never met this gentleman.’

‘What about this man?’ Sharma told her, pointing at me.

‘I have never met him till my arrest. I first saw him in the police van. But the inspector showed a few photographs of his, too, and trained me to remember the name Nambi Narayanan.’

Fauziyya’s identification exercise too went off on the same lines. Chandrasekar and S K Sharma were brought to identify Srivastava, and both of them failed to do so. In fact, all the six accused told the interrogators that they have never seen this man in their life, earlier.

I felt sad for the senior IPS officer. A man respected in service and outside has been dragged into this cesspool. How? Why? I was to learn how bitter politics between two factions in the Congress in Kerala—one led by then Chief Minister K Karunakaran, and the other by A K Antony and his Man Friday Oommen Chandy—made this officer a scapegoat.